SPARRING WITH THE CHINESE

The urgency of the first few days had slackened somewhat as the Chinese seemed quite content to stay on the northern side of the Tawang Chu. The opinion expressed by the corps commander, Kaul, was that nothing much was going to happen until the spring of 1963 when he planned to launch an attack to reclaim Tawang. In fact, during his visit to Se-la, he berated one of the commanding officers for spending so much time on the defences, insisting that it was more prudent to stock up for the winter. In keeping with this thinking, the majority of the mines were not laid, for it was felt that in the coming period of heavy snow, they would first get buried and then shift their position.

Having withdrawn from Jang, it was important that 62 Infantry Brigade remain in contact with the Chinese. Across the valley, from the general direction of Tawang, explosions could be heard day and night as the Chinese worked feverishly on a road that would link Bum-la and Tawang. At night, lights illuminating the stretches under construction could be seen, while Chinese movement at the base of the valley was under observation by the Garhwalis. On 1 November Brigadier Hoshiar Singh sent a fighting patrol from 4 Garhwal Rifles under Major H. B. Rai. Accompanying him as the forward observation officer (FOO) was Major Devinder Goswami of 2 Derajat Mountain Battery. The objective of the Garhwal patrol was to destroy the Lao footbridge over the Mago Chu (approximately twenty kilometres east of the Nuranang Falls) and could be used by the Chinese to infiltrate into the Dirang Valley via Jangle.

On reaching Lao, the patrol found the Chinese occupying both ends of the bridge. Rai was not too enthused about taking on the Chinese. The FOO engaged the bridge but the artillery failed to hit the narrow target, though they did cause some casualties to the Chinese troops and damaged the support structure of the bridge on either side of the river. The patrol returned to Battalion HQ on 6 November.

Later that same day, 2 Sikh LI sent out a patrol under Captain M. K. Saxena with four other ranks to reconnoitre the track from Kye-la up to the Mago Chu and observe Chinese activity along the river up to Bridge 3. They were spotted by the Chinese and had to beat a hasty retreat, during the course of which two soldiers were killed. Their bodies could only be recovered four days later. The Chinese had in the meantime taken their